







REARVIEW MIRROR
(clockwise from left) 'The Imperial Durbar' (The Durbar of 1903); 'The Western Entrance of Shere Shah's Fort, Delhi' by Thomas Daniell (1796); Gandhi poster (c. 1960); 'Scarcity in India' by Henry Singleton (1794); 'Slum Musician' by Sudhir Khastgir (1957); 'Street Scene Lahore' by V. Veevers (1935)

you feel about this? [...] Have you heard of similar stories today?" The allusions that the card makes—the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor first comes to mind—seem both wry and clever, but, elsewhere, near a poster for the film *Mother India*, one feels disappointed when one reads: "How would you imagine 'Mother India?'? Would she look more like your own mother, and less like a goddess?" This is just plain spoon-feeding.

Of the 159 artworks and artefacts on display, the photographs can, in retrospect, seem strangely and acutely memorable. Henri Cartier-Bresson's photos of Mahatma Gandhi's last days and funeral are still somehow harrowing. Nemai Ghosh's picture of Bharatanatyam dancer Balasaraswati is affecting, while Raghu Rai's portrait of Ustad Bismillah Khan with a cigarette in hand and a smile on his lips feels equally mischievous and iconic. Rivalling these black-and-white photos are a collection of pre-1947 travel posters that help *March...* pop with a retro fluorescence. The striking 'See India' section highlights how the railways had made places as distant as Lahore, Ellora and Gaya suddenly accessible.

March to Freedom, it must be said, succeeds on several counts. Not only has it transformed a large section of the stodgy Indian Museum into a modern gallery space, it is also a timely reminder that we can approach Independence with delight instead of sombreness. Multiple visits would afford several takeaways, but chances are that one would again return to some obvious favourites: The slumdweller playing his harmonium with abandon in Sudhir Khastgir's 'Slum Musician'; the frightened child riding a carousel in Stella Brown's 1948 work 'Merry Go Round'. Much like *March...*, Brown's painting captures perfectly that dichotomy of Independence—the play of joy and sorrow, excitement and fear. ■

–Shreevasta Nevatia

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The theme of this virtual exhibition—"the unwavering and undying spirit of India"—seems familiar, yes, but the archival footage and art on show all make for an experience that is altogether immersive.